GALWAY COMMUNITY COLLEGE

CODE OF BEHAVIOUR

ADOPTED COPY

THIS POLICY HAS BEEN PREPARED IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE GUIDELINES PRODUCED BY THE NATIONAL EDUCATION WELFARE BOARD AS PER THE EDUCATION (WELFARE) ACT 2000 SECTION 23.

THIS POLICY HAS BEEN PREPARED IN CONSULTATION WITH PARENTS, STUDENTS, STAFF, BOARD OF MANAGEMENT AND GALWAY ROSCOMMON EDUCATION AND TRAINING BOARD (GRETB).

Adopted by the Board of Management: 27th September 2017

Adopted by GRETB: 10th October 2017

MISSION STATEMENT

We aim to create a caring atmosphere where students are encouraged and helped to develop their unique gifts and talents. We provide the academic and vocation skills that enable students to attain their maximum potential and participate fully as good citizens in society. Working in partnership with parents and community, we strive, to ensure the intellectual, spiritual, physical, emotional and social needs of each individual is developed.

This Statement is based on core values:

- Our school is a welcoming, secure and challenging learning environment.
- Education is a partnership between school, parents/guardians and students.
- Our purpose is to develop each pupil's confidence, potential and moral values.
- The importance and value of all members of the school community should be at the heart of all decisions and actions.

Every child in our care is entitled to learn in an environment which is happy, caring and stimulating. Where each individual can learn without fear of bullying or physical abuse, and where consideration, courtesy and respect is shown to all people at all times, in the context of a caring ethos.

LINK TO MISSION STATEMENT

Good behaviour is essential for effective teaching and learning to take place in school. This Code provides a just and reasonable system to ensure responsible behaviour by students, staff and parents/guardians. Affirmation and reward of good behaviour by school and home is a fundamental part of this Code of Behaviour. The Code of Behaviour and the expectations set our therein are based on respect for others, a commitment to study and participation in the life of the school.

ROLE OF EACH MEMBER OF THE SCHOOL COMMUNITY IN THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE CODE OF BEHAVOUR

STUDENTS

Each student must give a commitment to accept the Code of Behaviour and to fulfil the expectations as set out in the code. This will ensure the creation and maintenance of a good learning environment.

PARENTS

Parents/Guardians have a duty to support the school in implementing a fair and just Code of Behaviour. Acceptance of the Code of Behaviour by Parents/Guardians is required on enrolment of a student in the school.

TEACHERS

Each teacher has responsibility for the maintenance of discipline within his/her class and share with other teachers, students and parents a common responsibility for good order with the school and school grounds.

CLASS TUTOR

The Class Tutor monitors the wellbeing of each student. He/She may intervene on disciplinary matters when requested to do so by subject teachers. The Class Tutor may also meet Parents/Guardian.

YEAR HEAD

The Year Head co-ordinates and administers the Class Tutor system and acts in consultation with teachers and Class Tutors in the area of discipline. The Year Head meets Parents/Guardians. The Year Head is responsible for monitoring punctuality, absences, uniform and liaising with academic and attendance monitors.

PASTORAL CARE TEAM

The Pastoral Care team act to support students in the school who may be experiencing difficulties. Their role is to work in a supportive way with the Student, Tutor, School Completion Programme and Home School Liaison Officer.

HOME SCHOOL LIAISON OFFICER

The Home School Liaison Officer ensures a close link between parents, students and school.

DISCIPLINE TEAM

The Discipline Team meet every Thursday to monitor teachers comments and recommend sanctions.

DEPUTY PRINCIPAL

The Deputy Principal has responsibility for co-ordinating discipline in the school. He/She will ensure, with the co-operation of all staff, good order prevails in the school. He/She will be consulted by the Year Heads and Class Tutors regarding such matters. In the absence of the Principal He/She acts for the Principal.

PRINCIPAL

The Principal has final responsibility for the day-to-day running of the school. He/She ensures that the implementation of sanctions is fair, equitable and appropriate.

BOARD OF MANAGEMENT

The Board of Management gives formal approval to the Code of Behaviour and supports the Principal and Teaching Staff in the fair and just implementation of the Code. The Board of Management hears appeals by the Parents/Guardians against the decision of the Principal to suspend and/or expel a student.

EXPECTATIONS

In defining the Code, consideration has been given to the particular needs and circumstances in this school. The aim is to provide a framework for reasonable and responsible behaviour by all concerned staff, parents and students alike, and to ensure that every reasonable effort is made to accommodate the individuality of each student while acknowledging the right of each student to education in a disruption-free environment. The Code extends to the environs of the school, to school outings and trips and while travelling to and from school.

(An Abridged version of our school rules is included as Appendix 1 in the Code of Behaviour).

1. Students should attend school every day and arrive on time for each class
   This means:
   You attend every day unless it is absolutely unavoidable.
   If you miss school you bring a note of explanation to your Tutor.
   Absences must be explained by a note from Parent/s to Tutor.
   If you are late you must sign in at the office and have a note of explanation.
   If you must leave school during the day, you bring a note and get permission from the Deputy Principal or Principal and sign a special register book. (Parental permission must be received before a student can leave the school during normal timetable hours).
   You arrive at all classes on time and not delay on the way.

Because:

Progress at school requires optimum attendance and punctuality.

The Education Welfare Act 2000 legally requires parents to inform the school regarding all absences.

The school is responsible for you during school time.

Good attendance and good timekeeping helps a full class do well.

2. Students should do your best to work both in class and at your homework

   This means:

   You listen to your teachers and concentrate on learning and being attentive.

   You allow teachers to teach and fellow students to learn.

   You do not disturb the class.

   You do your homework each night written and oral, it must be completed on time, in full, to the highest possible standard, and be ready for inspection.

   You always carry your journal and take down homework in it.

   You come properly prepared for your subjects, i.e. you have all your copies, pens and any other specialist equipment required.

   Because:

   The teacher has a right to teach and all students have a right to learn in an environment free from disruption.

   Homework is an essential part of the learning process.

3. Students must come to school in full uniform, clean and tidy.

   This means:

   You wear the prescribed school uniform.

   If missing any item of school uniform, report to the Deputy Principal.

   Full uniform must be worn with pride from the time you leave your home until you return, and during out of school activities.

   Because:

   This is the uniform agreed to by parents, students and the school authorities.

   We all have a responsibility to maintain the image of school.

4. Students must have respect and consideration for other students

   This means:

   Every individual has the right to be treated with respect, tolerance, understanding and in a just manner.

   Being fair to everyone.

   Helping other students if they need help.

   Not picking on or bullying other students.

   Not fighting in or out of school.

   Respect for property of students and teachers.

   Respect school property.

Because:

Mutual respect is important.

Bullying can cause fear and hurt. We want our school to be a safe place.

Defacing/Damaging school property is destructive and shows a lack of respect for the school community of which the student is a member.

5. Students must show courtesy, consideration and good manners in your dealings while travelling to and from school, in school or on school trips.

   This means:

   All students show politeness, respect and courteous co-operation to all school staff, fellow students, visitors to the school, bus drivers and members of the community at all times.

   Visitors to the school are to be welcomed and directed to the Secretary's office.

   Bad mannered, disruptive or dangerous behaviour is not tolerated.

   Knock before entering a class or office.

   Because:

   We should treat others as we like to be treated ourselves.

6. That your respect the school environment.

   This means:

   Keeping the school clean and free of litter.

   Litter must be placed in bins.

   No chewing gum.

   Not retuning to the school grounds after school hours/weekends/holidays without permission from the school Principal or Deputy Principal.

   You do not damage school property.

   Because:

   Everybody benefits from working and learning in a pleasant environment.

7. *Students should not possess or smoke cigarettes in school.*

   The school Substance Abuse Policy forbids possession or use of cigarettes on school premises or while engaging in school activities.

8. *Students should not use mobile phones during class time.*

   Where students must bring mobile phones to school, they should be left in the student's locker. Where teachers form the opinion that the student's mobile phone causes a disruption of any sort, it will be confiscated. It must be given to the teacher on request and it will be left in the school office for the remainder of the day.

9. *Addictive Substances e.g. alcohol and unprescribed drugs are strictly banned in Galway Community College.*

   Should a student have alcohol or unprescribed drugs on their possession the school will be obliged to inform parents/guardians and the relevant authorities.

10. *The Student Journal*

    The student journal is an essential part of communication between teachers and parents. All students are issued with a journal by the school and are required to have it in class at all times. Failure to produce the journal when required to do so by a teacher is a breach of the Code of Behaviour. Students who deface their school journal will be required to replace it and may be subject to the appropriate sanctions.

SANCTIONS/DISCIPLINARY PROCEDURES

It is hoped that a student and their parents/guardians will respond positively to any sanctions imposed and that the student will reflect on their unacceptable behaviour, accept responsibility and change their future behaviour to meet the expectations of the school. Breaches of the code will be based on the referral system.

Sanctions for misbehaviour are usually progressive. (A guide to breaches of the code and example sanctions is included as Appendix 2 to this Code of Behaviour). (A stage process of dealing with behaviour issues has been introduced and is included as Appendix 3 to this Code of Behaviour).

In serious incidents of misbehaviour normal disciplinary procedures will be abridged and the issue referred to the Year Head, Deputy Principal or Principal.

While it is not common the Board of Management may, in exceptional circumstances, form the opinion that a student should be expelled for a first offence. The kinds of behaviour that might result in a proposal to expel on the basis of a single breach of the code could include:

- A serious threat of violence against another student or member of staff
- Actual violence or physical assault
- Supplying illegal drugs to other students in the school
- Sexual assault

SUBJECT TEACHER IN CLASS

- The teacher has primary responsibility for discipline within his/her own classroom.
- In general the teacher will handle all the day-to-day problems that arise in the classroom.
- All teachers have a role both inside and outside the classroom in relation to discipline.
- Each teacher applies the Code of Discipline in a fair and just manner.
- Punishment to be effective must be known and understood by all the class.

- When the subject teacher is faced with a persistent offender, then the matter is referred to the Class Tutor. The class tutor will explore with the student the reasons for their misbehaviour and if there is no improvement in the student's behaviour, the Class Tutor will refer the matter to the Year Head.
- The subject teacher should record all instances of misdemeanour and positive comments on vsware.

YEAR HEAD

The Year Head may proceed as follows:

- Full details are taken by the Year Head of the incident or repeated misbehaviour.
- Arrangements are made if necessary to contact or interview the Parents/Guardians.
- She/He may decide to deal with the matter (e.g. place on report) or may bring the matter before the Discipline team depending on the seriousness of the incident.
- The Year Head should record all instances of misbehaviour and positive comments on vsware.
- For serious disciplinary matters the Parent/Guardian may be contacted immediately and asked to come to the school to discuss the matter with the Year Head and may be asked to remove the student from the school for the reminder of the day. A student should not be sent home during school hours, except in the care of his/her Parent/Guardian.

DISCIPLINE TEAM

- Before the Discipline Team meets, the Parent/Guardian must be informed and give the opportunity to come to the school and discuss the matter with the Year Head if they so wish. The Parent/Guardian does not attend the Discipline Team meeting.

SCHOOL DETENTION

The Deputy Principal and Principal may use lunch time or after school detention as the first sanction for serious breaches of the school Code of Behaviour. Should a student fail to attend two lunch time detentions or be placed on and attend three lunchtime detentions they will be placed on after school detention on Friday. In such instances Parents will receive 24 hours notification and detention will last for one hour. In certain instances Saturday or holiday detention may also be given with the prior approval of the Parent/Guardian. The Deputy Principal and Principal should record all instances of misdemeanour and positive comments on vsware.

SUSPENSION AND EXPULSION

The grounds for expulsion may be similar to the grounds for suspension. In addition to factors such as the degree of seriousness and the persistence of the behaviour, a key difference is that, where expulsion is considered, the school may have tried a series of other interventions, and believe they have exhausted all possibilities for changing the student's behaviour. However as mentioned previously some of the steps will be abridged for very serious incidents of misbehaviour. Internal suspension within the school may also be used as a means of sanction for persistent breaches of the Code of Behaviour.

Serious or persistent breaches of the school Code of Behaviour which can result in suspension and/or expulsion include:

- Serious or persistent disruption of teaching and learning.
- The use of obscene, offensive or abusive language in word or writing in the school or towards any person.
- Theft of, vandalism or damage to, school property or the personal property of others.
- Persistent bullying of another student or staff member. (In the event that a student does not engage with the anti-bullying policy and the anti-bullying team the matter becomes a discipline issue and suspension or expulsion may be considered in serious circumstances).
- Unauthorised use of fire doors, alarms or health and safety equipment.
- Persistent failure to wear the school uniform.
- Failure to have report cards signed by each teacher.
- Interference with the personal lives of teachers at home or outside the school.

In all cases of verbal or physical aggression towards a staff member or another student a suspension is applied. (The type of suspension is at the discretion of the Principal or Deputy Principal).

The school authorities deem the incidents below as very serious breaches of the Code of Behaviour and will warrant all steps to be abridged. <u>These include:</u>

- Selling alcohol, drugs or related substances (unprescribed medication or legal drug substitutes for illegal drugs).
- In possession of alcohol, drugs or related substances for supply.
- Acts of physical violence towards students or staff members.
- Acts of sexual harassment towards students or staff members.
- Any act which endangers the Health and Safety and Welfare of themselves or others in the school.
- Theft of, vandalism or damage to, school property or the personal property of others.

It is not possible to list all serious offences and the above list is used as a guide for the school management as an indication of the seriousness of the offences that may warrant suspension/expulsion.

In all cases of suspension this is a decision of the Principal having heard all sides and considered the case. Parents will be notified in advance of the suspension. A report on all suspensions imposed will be made to the Board of Management.

A sub-committee of the board may also meet to discuss with a student and their Parent/Guardian the student's behaviour in the school. This meeting is to facilitate where possible an agreed level of behaviour. This responsibility has been delegated to the Chairperson and two other members. Where possible the Education Welfare Officer will also be invited to such a meeting. Where a student has been suspended for an incident of serious misbehaviour he/she may be asked to sign a contract of acceptable behaviour upon their return to school.

The Board of Management has devolved responsibility to the Principal to suspend a student for up to three days or up to five days for serious breaches of the Code of Behaviour. A sub-committee of the Board can suspend for a further length of time would the need arise if a full Board meeting cannot be called. This responsibility has been delegated to the Chairperson and two other members.

The Board of Management decides on a recommendation from the Principal to expel a student following a hearing at which the Principal gives the reasons for his recommendation and the Parents/Guardians of the student may give reasons why the recommendation should not be approved.

In all cases of expulsion the Principal's recommendation to expel a student is subject to the decision of the Board of Management.

In all cases involving cumulative suspensions of more than twenty school days, the Parents/Guardians have the right of appeal to the Board of Management within 42 days of receiving notification, thereafter to GRETB and thereafter to the Secretary General of the Department of Education and Science under Section 29 of the Education Act (1998).

In all cases involving expulsion, the Parents/Guardians have the right of appeal to GRETB and thereafter to the Secretary General of the Department of Education and Science under Section 29 of the Education Act (1998).

The Education Welfare Service are notified where the cumulative number of days for suspension reaches six or when a student is expelled from school or refused enrolment or where there are education welfare concerns. The contact details of the local office are Unit 19, Sandyfort Business Centre, Grealishtown, Bohermore, Galway. Tel. 091 385302 and Fax 091 670915.

PROMOTING AND REWARDING GOOD BEHAVIOUR

The school places a significant emphasis on promoting and rewarding good behaviour. This is done in a number of ways:

- Through affirmation and acknowledgement by the teacher in class and in the student journal.
- At Parent/Teacher meetings, Assemblies, Newsletters, end of Year ceremonies and local publications.

We set high expectations for all our students and endeavour to create a positive learning environment. Promoting positive behaviour is expanded upon further in our Promoting Positive Behaviour Guidelines for Students, Teachers and Parents.

REVIEW AND EVALAUATION OF THIS POLICY

The implementation, monitoring and review of this policy will be done by senior management in conjunction with the staff, parents and Board of Management on an ongoing basis. It is envisaged that the policy would be reviewed on a formal basis within five years after the date of adoption by the Board of Management.

Date adopted by the Board of Management; *27th September 2017*

GALWAY COMMUNITY COLLEGE

OUR SCHOOL RULES

In School

- I will come to school everyday
- I will wear my full uniform everyday
- I will bring all of the books and equipment
- I will bring my Journal
- I will follow staff instructions calmly
- I will not smoke or use any illegal substances
- I will use a mobile phone only during break
- I will be on time at all times
- I will walk calmly on the corridors on the left
- I will keep the school clean

With my school work

- I will give all my work my best effort and attention
- I will have what I need in class to do my best work
- I will listen and talk kindly
- I will do my homework

With others

- I will allow others to learn
- I will treat others with respect and kindness
- I will never harm others or their property

REMEMBER: If I come to school without full uniform, bag or without a journal I will be sent home to get them.

Appendix 2

Level 1: Low Level disruption dealt with by the **Classroom Teacher**

DESIRED BEHAVIOUR IN CLASS

1. Listen
2. One voice only at a time
3. Remember to follow school rules
4. Show respect for people and property
5. Attend all classes
6. Be on time
7. Wear your full uniform
8. Co-operate
9. Speak kindly
10. Ask for help

BREACHES WITHIN THE CLASSROOM MAY INCLUDE

- Late for class
- Failure to bring equipment, eg. Bag, Books etc.
- Having mobile phone/personal equipment, earphones etc in full view.
- Non-stop talking.
- Failure to complete work.
- Refusal to follow instructions.

INTERVENTIONS

- Verbal warning
- Knock, re-enter, sit
- Note in diary
- SNA Intervention
- Short Detention by classroom teacher
- 2 chance warning
- Reminder of agreed rules
- Move seat
- Sent to different classroom
- Report sheet
- Extra homework
- Reflection Sheet
- Note in Journal to be signed by parents

DESIRED BEHAVIOUR ON CORRIDOR

- ✓ No Running
- ✓ Respect people and property
- ✓ Walk on the Left
- ✓ Do what staff member asks

BREACHES ON THE CORRIDOR

- Running on the corridor
- Messing on the corridor
- Disrespect

INTERVENTION

- ✓ Reminder of agreed rules
- ✓ Supervised break time by designated personal

Low Level Behaviour issues as listed will be dealt with by the staff member who encounters them.

Level 2: Mid Level disruption dealt with by the **Classroom Teacher**

DESIRED BEHAVIOUR IN CLASS

1. Listen
2. One voice only at a time
3. Remember to follow school rules
4. Show respect for people and property
5. Attend all classes
6. Be on time
7. Wear your full uniform
8. Co-operate
9. Speak kindly
10. Ask for help

BREACHES WITHIN THE CLASSROOM MAY INCLUDE

- Rude Gestures
- Horseplay and chasing
- Verbal and physical disrespect
- Time wasting
- Ignorance and Apathy
- Skipping Classes
- Intentionally defying
- Mobile Phone out during Class
- Continued breaches at Level 1

INTERVENTIONS

- Tutor Involvement
- Remove to another class
- Warning followed by confiscation of phone
- Colour coded levels of warning
- Team teacher remove student
- Litter duty
- Remove privileges
- Lunchtime detention
- Student makes contact with parents through teacher
- Behaviour support sheet
- Continuous use of interventions at Level 1.

DESIRED BEHAVIOUR ON CORRIDOR

- ✓ No Running
- ✓ Respect people and property
- ✓ Walk on the Left
- ✓ Do what staff member asks

BREACHES ON THE CORRIDOR

- Running on the corridor
- Messing on the corridor
- Disrespect

INTERVENTION

- ✓ Reminder of agreed rules
- ✓ Supervised break time by designated personal

Key to understanding Mid Level Behaviour issues is the planned, purposeful and deliberate way the student behaves having received repeated behaviour interventions as outlined.

Level 3: High Level disruption dealt with by the Tutor, Year Head, Deputy Principal and Principal as part of a Whole School Approach

DESIRED BEHAVIOUR IN SCHOOL

1. Speak to others as you would like to be spoken to.
2. Treat others as you would like to be treated
3. Be Honest
4. Be Responsible
5. Take Care of others
6. Attend all Classes
7. Co-operate
8. Be Punctual

You have a right to a safe school and you have a responsibility to make it safe.

BREACHES WITHIN THE CLASSROOM MAY INCLUDE

- Verbal Abuse
- Violent Behaviour
- Spitting
- Disrespect and Bullying
- Racism and Name Calling
- Vandalism
- Discriminatory Behaviour
- Assault/Fighting
- Possession/Distribution of Alcohol
- Possession/Distribution of Drugs
- Possession/Distribution of Pornography
- Possession/Distribution of Weapons
- Theft
- Throwing Items across the Classroom/Corridor
- Recording material without permission
- Persistently skipping classes
- Continued breaches at level 2

INTERVENTIONS

- Year Head Involvement
- Suspensions
- Friday after school detention
- Parents contacted by letter
- Behaviour committee
- Board of management involvement
- Permanent exclusion
- Counselling
- Referral to external agency
- Re-introduction of pupil in class in negotiation with the teacher involved

Key to understanding High Level Behaviour issues is the planned, purposeful and deliberate way the student behaves having received repeated behaviour interventions as outlined.

Stage 1:

Stage 1 is issued to a student by means of a formal reprimand by the class teacher for consistent and persistent breaches of the Code of Behaviour which impact negatively upon the teaching and learning process. This stage is time limited and will be removed upon review if behaviour improves. Detention but not suspension should be considered at this stage. (In the case of consistent breaches of the Code of Behaviour the tutor should be advised and they may also issue Stage 1)

Stage 2:

Stage 2 is issued by the Year Head/Deputy Principal having spoken to the student at length with regard to his/her negative behaviour. Time limited and parents informed in writing. Short suspension may be considered at this stage along with other punishments.

Stage 3:

Stage 3 is issued by the Principal/Deputy Principal and calls a meeting with parents and the schools disciplinary team.
Extended suspension may be considered at this stage. Upon re-entry into school parents and student sign a contract of behaviour.

Stage 4:

Stage 4 is issued by the Principal. The Principal informs EWO and an Educational Welfare Conference is called to address all aspects of the students continuing poor behaviour which are beginning to threaten the students place in the school. Plans and supports are put in place to assist student, school and family. Suspension should be until EWC can be held.

Stage 5:

Stage 5 is issued by the Principal. The Parents are invited to meet the Board of Management's sub-committee on student discipline. Gravity of the situation is outlined clearly to student and his/her family.
Should the negative behaviour continue at this point the Principal is now obliged to recommend permanent exclusion. Student is suspended until full BOM meeting is held to consider the case.

Note: (Extract taken from Code of Behaviour 2017. Pg 10.)

The school authorities deem the incidents below as very serious breaches of the Code of Behaviour and will warrant all steps to be abridged. <u>These include:</u>

- Selling alcohol, drugs or related substances (unprescribed medication or legal drug substitutes for illegal drugs).
- In possession of alcohol, drugs or related substances for supply.
- Acts of physical violence towards students or staff members.
- Acts of sexual harassment towards students or staff members.
- Any act which endangers the Health and Safety and Welfare of themselves or others in the school.
- Theft of, vandalism or damage to, school property or the personal property of others.